

Share the following guidelines with your recommender. It will help them write a more effective letter of recommendation (LOR) that will strengthen your overall application.

General guidelines for writing an effective letter of recommendation (LOR):

- A LOR is an important piece of an application. In some cases, the LOR can make the difference between a “yes” and a “no”.
- A LOR is not only a required component of any business school application, but it is an opportunity to provide the admissions committee with information that will also help to reinforce the candidate’s work experience and help to highlight, from an outside perspective, the personal and leadership qualities they have chosen to emphasize throughout their application.
- In order to write a personal LOR, it is important to understand why the candidate is pursuing an MBA: what are their short- and long-term goals? Why have they chosen their specific set of schools? What do they think their strengths/weaknesses are?
- Your recommendation is an opportunity to provide the admission committee with an objective opinion regarding how the applicant has performed, not only in comparison to his/her peers, but also the impact they have had on your company/organization.
- A LOR is an opportunity for you to not only highlight what makes this candidate unique, but also to impress upon the admissions committee how an MBA will ultimately help them along their career path.
- It is important to customize the LOR for each school. In some cases, there is a “Common Letter of Recommendation” that many schools have implemented (the LOR is exactly the same for these schools). In this case, make small edits to your LOR to personalize the content for that school.
- If you are alumnus of a particular school, or affiliated with the school in any capacity, it will be important to highlight why you think this candidate will be a good fit with the culture of the program. Comment on how your experience with this person has influenced your opinion of how the candidate will successful both in the program and beyond.

How do I write an effective LOR?

- **Provide context.** The admissions committee reads thousands of applications and letters of recommendation. Paint a picture for the reader about the type of environment the candidate is functioning from, and your role within this ecosystem. This is especially important if you work in a niche industry, one that the reader may not be familiar with.
- **Be specific.** Provide specific examples where possible: how much revenue did the candidate generate? How many people do they manage? Can you write about a specific

project that the candidate went above and beyond their scope on? Give specific examples of how they have performed.

- **Provide details.** Specific examples are just one part of the story. Examples should be backed up by evidence (the details). It can be easy to make a statement such as: “Julie is the most talented account executive I have ever worked with”. However, it needs to be followed by “...and here’s why...”.
- **What vs. HOW.** It is critical in a LOR to tell the story of how this person has performed, rather than a simple statement of what they have done (see point about being specific above!)
- **Be realistic.** Many schools will ask you to rate/rank the candidate on a number of criteria. Although it may be tempting to select the highest ranking for all categories, it is more realistic to assess the candidate a mix of the top 2 score levels. It will not only show objectivity but will also show that you have given some thought to each point.
- **Be honest.** Although the LOR is your opportunity to provide the admissions committee with a third party perspective on what makes this person an outstanding candidate for an MBA, it is also an opportunity to help the committee understand how an MBA will help this person on their path to achieving their personal and professional goals. This should include an honest assessment of their weaknesses/areas for growth and improvement (we all have them!), and many schools will specifically ask you to comment on this. It is important to highlight how the candidate received the feedback, and how they implemented a strategy to improve.
- **Compare.** When possible, use your experience working with/managing people to help distinguish this candidate from those with a with a similar background.
- **Get personal.** The LOR is a unique opportunity to shed light on an aspect of someone’s candidacy that they may not be able to do so themselves, through their essays, resume, etc. Highlight personal qualities that you find particularly important to this person’s success. Use specific examples when possible (see second bullet above!).